WHO'S WHO IN THE RAM TEMPLE TRUST

Key members include Ram temple movement veterans, bureaucrats, other nominees

MAHANT NRITYA GOPAL DAS, *88*
Chairman



Ramanandi seer-scholar. Succeeded the late Ramchandra Paramhans, one of the biggest leaders of the Ayodhya movement, as Ram Janmabhoomi Nyas president. Mostly inactive

CHAMPAT RAI, *80*
General Secretary



The VHP vice-president was for decades one of the principal strategists of the Ram temple movement. Was the all-powerful overlord of all temple affairs till the scandal broke. Has resigned from the Trust

K. PARASARAN, *98*
Founding trustee



Senior Supreme Court lawyer, former Attorney General of India. Led Hindu side in the marathon lead-up to the final 2019 SC verdict in the Ayodhya title dispute

SWAMI GOVIND DEV GIRI, *77; Treasurer*



Aloof in the early phase of the theft controversy, the Pune-based preacher is also on the SKJB trust, Mathura

NRIPENDRA MISRA, *80*
Chairman, Ram Temple Construction Committee



The former principal secretary to the prime minister oversaw the technical and infrastructural aspects of the Ram temple construction

SHANKARACHARYA SWAMI VASUDEVANAND SARASWATI, *75; Trustee*



The Badrinath jyotish peeth shankaracharya has otherwise been involved in legal tussles over the succession there with two other seers, Swaroopanand Saraswati and Avimukteshwaranand

MADHVACHARYA SWAMI VISHWAPRASANNATIRTHA, *75; Trustee*



The 33rd pontiff of the Pejawar Math in Udupi, Karnataka, succeeding Swami Vishweshatirtha, who passed away in 2019

DR ANIL KUMAR MISHRA, *70*
Trustee



Retired homeopath in Ayodhya and RSS veteran. Was a low-profile, local organisational man during Ayodhya agitation. Supervised donation counting centre at the temple. Has resigned

Adityanath announced a three-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) on June 13 to investigate not just the specific acts of corruption but also to examine the entire chain through which donations were received, counted, stored and deposited. Over the following days, operating in a surcharged political atmosphere, investigators scrutinised nearly a year of financial records, extracted hidden and tampered CCTV data, analysed bank transactions and questioned officials of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust (SRJTKT), bank employees and those who counted the cash. On June 23, the SIT submitted its preliminary report, detailing as many as 70 instances of theft, totalling Rs 7.9 crore. Two days later, the Ayodhya police registered an FIR, naming eight accused involved in counting and depositing donations, and arresting them. But with the scandal taking on wider dimensions, two key custodians of the SRJTKT—Champat Rai, general secretary, and Anil Mishra, trustee—submitted their resignations.

'Chanda Chori'

The Opposition was quick to put both the central and state government on the mat. Terming it "*chanda chori*" (donation theft), Akhilesh Yadav, leader of the Opposition in the UP assembly, launched a fusillade of questions: why had key CCTV footage of the donation cash counting gone missing? Had cash been diverted to political coffers? How could a government investigate itself? As events unwound, the questions seemed to multiply. Aam Aadmi Party leader Sanjay Singh raked up an older probe that had quietly buried allegations of big-ticket land deals in Ayodhya by the SRJTKT. Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge